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THE ACADEMY

WEEK 8 · THE INDEPENDENT PATH

Going Independent

HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

Read this once for the shape of it. Read it a second time with your own numbers in front of you: the salary of the role you do now, the cost of a month of your life, the size of your savings. This module is not theory; it is a business plan you are deciding whether to write.

The independent path

What it is, who it is for, and when it is a mistake

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand the forms independent private service actually takes. Decide honestly whether, and when, it is for you. And know the concrete machinery — the company, the contract, the insurance, the pricing, the clients — before the day you need it rather than after.

1.1 · A DEFINITION

DEFINITION

Independent private service. Working for households not as their employee but as your own business: engaged for a defined role, project or period, invoicing for your time, carrying your own tax, insurance and risk, and often serving more than one principal across a year.

1.2 · THE FORMS IT TAKES

Independence is not one thing. In practice it is five, and most independents live across several of them in a year.

- **Temporary or interim.** You cover a gap — a resignation, a season, a parental leave — for weeks or months, at a daily or weekly rate.
- **Project work.** You are engaged for a defined outcome: a house move, a renovation, a wedding, the opening of a new residence, standing up a new family office.
- **Rotational.** Two weeks on, two weeks off, sharing a role with another professional. Common on yachts and at second homes.

- **Portfolio.** You hold light oversight of several households at once — a day or two each — none of which needs a full-time manager.
- **Consultancy.** You advise a family office or a principal on staffing, systems, security or a build, and never touch the day-to-day. This is the most senior, and the best paid per hour.

1.3 · WHEN IT MAKES SENSE, AND WHEN IT IS A MISTAKE

Independence rewards a reputation, a network and a nerve you do not have on your first day in this world. It is not a way in; it is a way up, taken late.

You are ready when four things are true at once: you have several years at a senior level behind you; you have references a family office will confirm; you already receive work unasked, through people who have seen you deliver; and you have a cash buffer that can carry your life through the empty months, because there will be empty months.

Going independent to escape a bad employer, or because a permanent role will not come, is the wrong reason — and the wrong reason shows. A principal can feel the difference between someone who chose independence and someone who is hiding in it.

The machinery

The unglamorous scaffolding that turns you from a person into a business

2.1 · THE LEGAL SHELL

You stop being paid as a person and start trading through a structure. The names differ by country — self-employed or sole trader, a limited company, an LLC — and the choice is a question for an accountant, driven by your income and your exposure. The principle is universal and it is simple: separate yourself from your business. A business bank account. Books kept from day one, not reconstructed in a panic. And a business name that is discreet and plain, never clever.

2.2 · INSURANCE IS NOT OPTIONAL

As an employee, the household carried the risk. Independent, you carry it, and this is the single most expensive mistake new independents make: they skip it.

Three cover the work that matters. **Professional indemnity**, if your advice or your work causes a financial loss. **Public liability**, if a person is hurt or property is damaged in the course of what you do. And **employer's liability**, the day you hire so much as one person yourself. A single uninsured incident does not end a contract; it ends a career, and sometimes more.

2.3 · EVERYTHING IN WRITING

Every engagement, however short, is a written agreement before you begin. It states the

scope — exactly what you do and, as importantly, what you do not. The rate, and what it includes. The dates, and the notice on each side. Expenses. And confidentiality, in the same terms you would expect of anyone near your own life.

THE RULE

If it is not written, it does not exist. The absence of a contract never protects you; it protects only the person who chose to write none.

2.4 · CONFIDENTIALITY, AND WHY IT IS HARDER NOW

Employed, you held the secrets of one house. Independent, you hold the secrets of several, and every new principal knows it. Your discretion is now your entire marketing. A single indiscretion about a past client is heard by every future one, correctly, as a promise about them.

Pricing your time

How to put a number on yourself without apology, and without guessing

3.1 · THE THREE SHAPES OF A FEE

- **Day rate.** A fixed sum per day worked. For interim and project work.
- **Retainer.** A monthly sum to be available and to hold light oversight of a household, paid whether or not every day is used.
- **Project fee.** A single agreed price for a defined outcome, fixed in advance so the risk of overrun is yours, not theirs — which is why you price it with care.

3.2 · HOW TO SET THE NUMBER

Begin from what the role pays as an employed position. Then correct for everything an employee receives and you no longer will.

The rough method: take the annual salary of the equivalent employed role. Divide by about 220 working days in a year. Then multiply by **1.6 to 2.5**. That multiple is not greed; it pays for the holiday you no longer get, the sick days you cannot take, the pension no one funds, your insurance, your accountant, your own admin, and above all the empty weeks between engagements. A role worth £70,000 employed is not £320 a day. It is closer to £550 to £750.

DEFINITION

Utilisation. The share of your available days you are actually paid for. Independents rarely bill more than sixty to seventy per cent of the year; the rest is sales, travel, admin and rest. If your rate does not already assume this, your rate is wrong.

3.3 · GETTING PAID

For projects, take a deposit — commonly a third to a half, before you start. Set plain terms:

payment within seven to fourteen days. Invoice the day the work is done, not the month after. And chase a late payment early, and without embarrassment: a household slow to pay a discreet supplier is telling you something you should hear.

Finding the work

Where independent engagements actually come from, in the order they arrive

4.1 · THE FOUR SOURCES

1. **Referral.** By a distance the largest. Your last principal, their peers, a family office that trusted you once. Independence is a reputation business long before it is a marketing one. 2. **Specialist agencies.** They take a margin and earn it: vetted clients, and the introduction handled. The serious houses that place permanent staff place interim and project roles too — register with them. 3. **Family offices, directly.** Often the true buyer of interim and project work, and the ones who remember you. 4. **A quiet, credible presence.** A plain one-page site. A restrained profile. Never loud, never a client's name. In this world you are found; you do not shout.

4.2 · THE REFERENCE PROBLEM, SOLVED

You cannot list your clients. So you do three things instead. You route every reference through the family office of the house concerned. You describe the role, its scale and its outcome without the name — "a single-family office in Geneva, nine staff across two residences, a full relocation delivered in ten weeks." And you let that unnamed, verifiable house become the strongest line you have.

The risks nobody prints in the brochure

- **No safety net.** No sick pay, no holiday pay, no pension, and gaps between the work. Hold a cash buffer of three to six months of your life before you begin, and keep it whole.
 - **You carry the liability.** Insured, but still, finally, yours.
 - **Isolation.** You belong to no house. The quiet belonging that made the employed role warm is gone, and some people feel its absence more than they expected.
 - **Reputation is the whole asset.** It takes years to build and one breach to end, and independent, you have no employer to absorb a mistake on your behalf.
 - **Tax and records.** Set aside your tax from every invoice, the day it is paid. Keep every receipt. And find an accountant before your first year closes, not after it.
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A worked example

One professional's first independent engagement, start to finish

She had run a single-family office household for six years, and left on good terms. Three months later, that principal's sister needed someone to open a new London residence: ten weeks, from empty rooms to a running house.

She agreed a day rate of £650, and a deposit of forty per cent before the first day. She wrote the scope in a single page: the house opened, staff hired and trained, systems and suppliers in place — and not the family's personal affairs, which were not hers to touch. Her professional indemnity and public liability were already current. She invoiced net-seven, and was paid on time because she had asked for it plainly.

She was never named in an advertisement. She had been referred, once, by a family office that had watched her work. When the ten weeks ended, the household kept her on a retainer of £2,000 a month, to hold light oversight from a distance. That one clean project became, quietly, the reference that brought the next three.

The one-page decision

Stay employed if you are still building your craft, if your references are thin, if the empty months would frighten you, or if you are running from something rather than toward it.

Go independent when the work already finds you, when a family office would confirm you tomorrow, when you can price yourself without apology, and when you can carry six empty weeks without losing your nerve or your home.

Glossary of the module

Day rate — a fixed sum per day worked. **Retainer** — a monthly sum for availability and light oversight. **Project fee** — a single agreed price for a defined outcome. **Utilisation** — the share of available days actually billed. **Professional indemnity** — cover for loss caused by your work or advice. **Public liability** — cover for injury or damage caused in your work. **Employer's liability** — cover required the moment you employ anyone. **Sole trader / self-employed** — the simplest legal shell. **Limited company / LLC** — a separate legal entity that limits your personal exposure. **Interim** — a temporary placement covering a gap. **Portfolio** — holding several part-time households at once. **Family office** — frequently the buyer, and the keeper of your reference.